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now •

🥷 Beyond AI and mental models, I've found a new obsession: geopolitics. 🙇

And the entry point was Simon Dixon. 🦉

I've been binging his podcasts, and what started as casual listening has turned into a complete reframing of how I read the news.

His thesis, simply put: "Stop watching the missiles. Start watching the money."

The Iran conflict that's been dominating headlines? Dixon argues it isn't really a war between nations. It's a power struggle between the Financial-Industrial Complex (FIC), which profits from managed transitions and reconstruction, and the Military-Industrial Complex (MIC), which profits from permanent conflict.

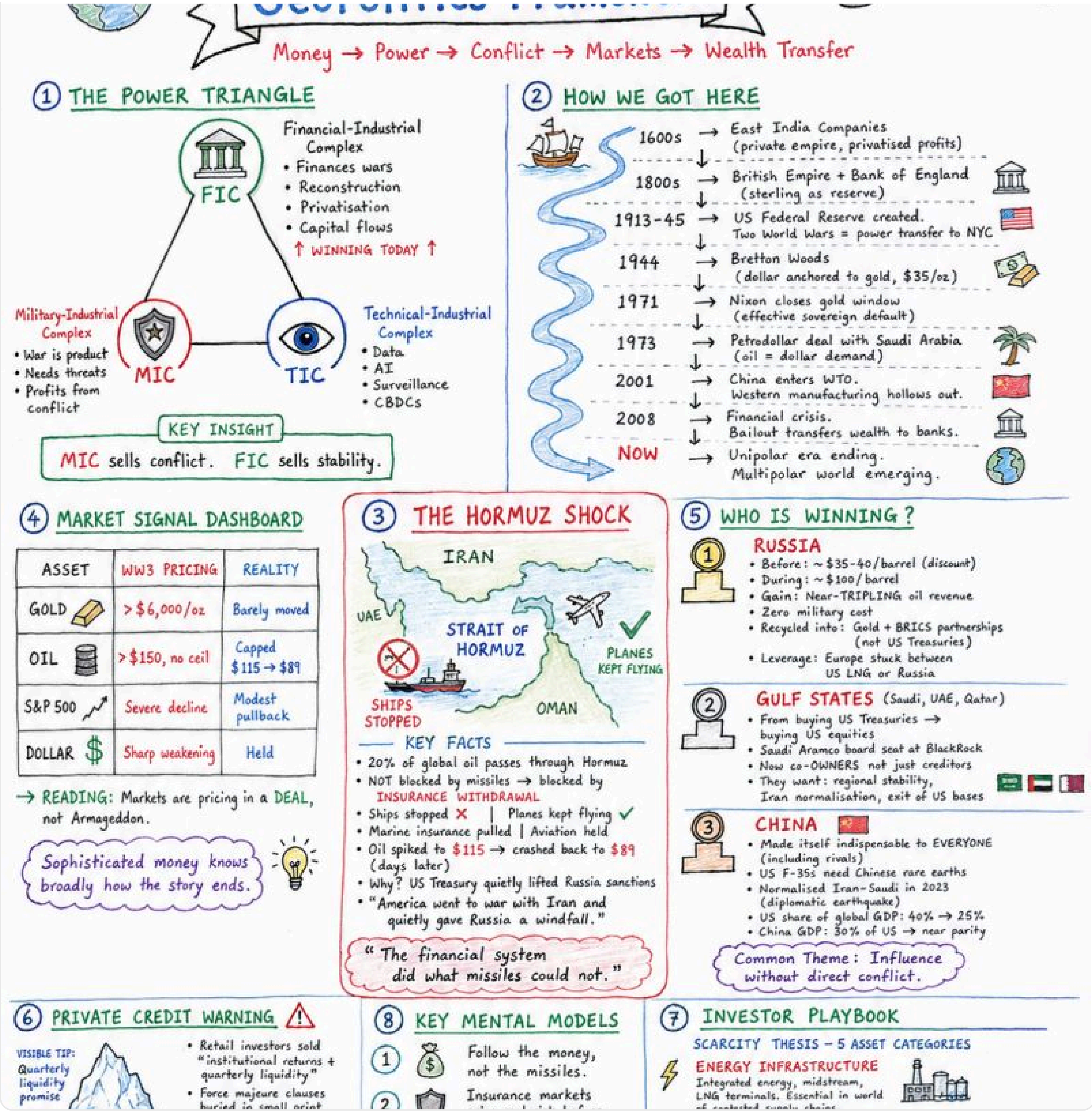
America went to war with Iran. Within days, the US Treasury quietly lifted sanctions on Russia to keep oil prices manageable. The price ceiling was the priority. Not the narrative.

I've put together a visual sketch note capturing the entire framework in one picture, attached below.

If you've never heard of Simon Dixon, or if geopolitics is new to you, this sketchnote is the entry point I think.

#Geopolitics #SimonDixon #MacroInvesting #FollowTheMoney #MentalModels #Bitcoin #Gold #MultiPolarWorld

(Note: Sketchnote is generated by AI, giving a detailed prompt and my hand-drawn past sketchnote as style-reference)



Money → Power → Conflict → Markets → Wealth Transfer
1 THE POWER TRIANGLE
FIC
Financial-Industrial Complex
• Finances wars
• Reconstruction
• Privatisation
• Capital flows
↑ WINNING TODAY ↑
Military-Industrial Complex
• War is product
• Needs threats
• Profits from conflict
MIC
TIC
Technical-Industrial Complex
• Data
• AI
• Surveillance
• CBDCs
KEY INSIGHT
MIC sells conflict. FIC sells stability.
2 HOW WE GOT HERE
1600s → East India Companies (private empire, privatised profits)
1800s → British Empire + Bank of England (sterling as reserve)
1913-45 → US Federal Reserve created. Two World Wars = power transfer to NYC
1944 → Bretton Woods (dollar anchored to gold, $35/oz)
1971 → Nixon closes gold window (effective sovereign default)
1973 → Petrodollar deal with Saudi Arabia (oil = dollar demand)
2001 → China enters WTO. Western manufacturing hollows out.
2008 → Financial crisis. Bailout transfers wealth to banks.
NOW → Unipolar era ending. Multipolar world emerging.
4 MARKET SIGNAL DASHBOARD
ASSET | WW3 PRICING | REALITY
GOLD | > $6,000/oz | Barely moved
OIL | > $150, no ceil | Capped $115 → $89
S&P 500 | Severe decline | Modest pullback
DOLLAR $ | Sharp weakening | Held
→ READING: Markets are pricing in a DEAL, not Armageddon.
Sophisticated money knows broadly how the story ends.
3 THE HORMUZ SHOCK
IRAN
UAE
STRAIT OF HORMUZ
PLANES KEPT FLYING
SHIPS STOPPED
OMAN
KEY FACTS
• 20% of global oil passes through Hormuz
• NOT blocked by missiles → blocked by INSURANCE WITHDRAWAL
• Ships stopped ✗ | Planes kept flying ✓
• Marine insurance pulled | Aviation held
• Oil spiked to $115 → crashed back to $89 (days later)
• Why? US Treasury quietly lifted Russia sanctions
• "America went to war with Iran and quietly gave Russia a windfall."
" The financial system did what missiles could not."
5 WHO IS WINNING?
1 RUSSIA
• Before: ~$35-40/barrel (discount)
• During: ~$100/barrel
• Gain: Near-TRIPLING oil revenue
• Zero military cost
• Recycled into: Gold + BRICS partnerships (not US Treasuries)
• Leverage: Europe stuck between US LNG or Russia
2 GULF STATES (Saudi, UAE, Qatar)
• From buying US Treasuries → buying US equities
• Saudi Aramco board seat at BlackRock
• Now co-OWNERS not just creditors
• They want: regional stability, Iran normalisation, exit of US bases
3 CHINA
• Made itself indispensable to EVERYONE (including rivals)
• US F-35s need Chinese rare earths
• Normalised Iran-Saudi in 2023 (diplomatic earthquake)
• US share of global GDP: 40% → 25%
• China GDP: 30% of US → near parity
Common Theme: Influence without direct conflict.
6 PRIVATE CREDIT WARNING
VISIBLE TIP: Quarterly liquidity promise
• Retail investors sold "institutional returns + quarterly liquidity"
• Force majeure clauses
8 KEY MENTAL MODELS
1 Follow the money, not the missiles.
2 Insurance markets
7 INVESTOR PLAYBOOK
SCARCITY THESIS – 5 ASSET CATEGORIES
ENERGY INFRASTRUCTURE
Integrated energy, midstream, LNG terminals. Essential in world